however, played a valuable role as an ‘unsung mediator’ in the crisis.[11] At 6.00pm EDT on 24 October, Thant had issued an appeal to Khrushchev and Kennedy, calling for a suspension of arms shipments to Cuba and a lifting of the blockade.

The appeal made no mention of the missiles in Cuba and was, therefore, not acceptable to Washington. When they spoke on the phone that evening, Macmillan told Kennedy it was ‘a very dangerous message’.[12] Khrushchev sent Thant a conciliatory response, but while Kennedy’s reply was still being processed, JFK asked the Secretary General to appeal directly to Khrushchev. Dorn and Pauk have shown that Thant’s message to Khrushchev on 25 October was in essence drafted by Washington (and quickly accepted by Moscow).[13] It provided a means by which Khrushchev could be seen to respond to the UN rather than JFK. The first planks of a golden bridge were being laid by the UN Secretary General at the behest of the US President.

The weekend of26-28 October marked the climax, as well as the denouement of the crisis. Key to what happened is how it happened. In other words, the means by which Moscow and Washington communicated with each other helped shaped various outcomes. In *Dr Strangelove*, President Muffley and Premier Kissof speak on the telephone. There is some difficulty locating the Soviet leader, which is resolved when Ambassador De Sadeski correctly surmises that Kissof is with his mistress (and that he is drunk). The two leaders converse in English and Muffley alludes to their previous conversations: ‘Look, Dimitri, you know we’ve always talked about the possibility of something going wrong with the bomb … you know the hydrogen bomb.’

Telephones could be used to communicate between Moscow and Washington. Kennedy made extensive use of them in his day-to day business. During the crisis, he spoke on the phone with Harold Macmillan, to inform, and indeed consult, the British Prime Minister as the crisis proceeded. The value of a telephone call was speed of communication. It also avoided putting things in writing. Bundy, for example, suggested a phone call to Moscow to make clear Khrushchev’s letter of 26 October was positive (in a way his letter of 27 October was not).[14]